

Eden Ofek Nalian
Department of Mathematics & Statistics
McMaster University
Hamilton, Ontario, Canada
eden.nalian@gmail.com

October 3, 2026

[PLACEHOLDER: Editor name, if known]

Editorial Office

[PLACEHOLDER: confirm target journal – this draft previously said “PLOS Digital Health,” but an earlier project ticket was written for “PLOS ONE”; confirm which journal before submission]

Dear Editors,

We are writing to submit our manuscript, “**Evaluation of automated table extraction for historical infectious-disease surveillance data**,” for consideration as a Research Article in [PLACEHOLDER: target journal name].

Most historical public-health data remain locked in scanned paper documents, limiting large-scale epidemiological research. We evaluate Amazon Textract, a cloud-based machine-learning document-extraction service, as an alternative to manual data entry, applying it to the Canadian Disease Incidence Dataset (CANDID), an archive of weekly disease counts for Canadian provinces and territories from 1956 to 1958. After a documented post-processing pipeline, automated extraction achieved 92.9% content-only cell-level agreement with the manually entered reference among cells numeric in that reference (95.6% under a stricter denominator); the epidemiologically relevant statistics we derive from the extracted data (cross-correlations, epidemic peak timing, and growth rates) were generally similar to those from the manual data, with quantified, documented differences. This work sits within [PLACEHOLDER: target journal]’s scope as a transparent, reproducible evaluation of a digital tool with direct implications for public health research practice, and we believe it will interest readers in digital health informatics, public health surveillance, and mathematical epidemiology.

We confirm this manuscript has not been published elsewhere and is not under consideration at any other journal, that all authors have read and approved it, and that the underlying data are publicly available (Data Availability statement). AI tools were used to assist with coding, L^AT_EX formatting, consistency checking, and language editing, as disclosed in the manuscript (Section 4.3, “Use of AI Tools”); all AI-assisted content was reviewed by the authors, who take full responsibility for the final manuscript. Funding information is in the submission system’s Financial Disclosure field (see `submission/financial-disclosure.txt` in the repository) rather than the manuscript, per journal policy. Competing interests: [PLACEHOLDER – manuscript currently states none declared].

We have not indicated a preferred Academic Editor and leave the assignment to the editorial team’s discretion. Suggested reviewers: [PLACEHOLDER]. Reviewers to exclude: [PLACEHOLDER].

We look forward to hearing from you.

Sincerely,

Eden Ofek Nalian (corresponding author)
Steven C. Walker and David J.D. Earn